

When Your Agent Stops Responding

Quick troubleshooting guide for OpenClaw outages and silent failures

If your agent suddenly stops responding on Telegram — no replies, stuck on "typing", or just silent — it doesn't always mean something is broken on your end. The most common reason is that the AI provider behind your agent (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, etc.) is having an outage. This guide walks you through how to check, what to do, and how to get your agent back up quickly.

Step 1 — Check the Provider Status Pages

Before you touch anything on your setup, check whether the AI provider you're using is actually up and running. Open the status page for your primary model's provider and see if there's an active incident.

Provider	Status Page URL
OpenAI (ChatGPT, Codex, GPT models)	status.openai.com
Anthropic (Claude models)	status.anthropic.com
Google (Gemini models)	status.cloud.google.com
OpenRouter (MiniMax, Kimi, etc.)	status.openrouter.ai
Moonshot (Kimi direct)	platform.moonshot.ai
General outage tracker	downdetector.com

If the status page shows an active incident: That's your answer. The provider is down and there's nothing wrong with your setup. You can either wait for them to fix it (usually 30 minutes to a few hours), or switch to a different model temporarily using the steps below.

Step 2 — Why Your Fallback Models Might Not Kick In

You might be wondering: I set up fallback models, so why isn't my agent switching to one of them automatically?

The answer is that fallback only works when the provider returns a clear error, like "service unavailable" or "unauthorized". During some outages, the provider doesn't return an error at all — it just stops responding and your agent sits there waiting for an answer that never comes. When this happens, the fallback chain never gets triggered because from the agent's point of view, the request is still "in progress".

This is a known limitation. It happens most often during large-scale outages where the provider's servers are overloaded rather than completely offline. The good news is you can fix it manually in a couple of minutes using the steps below.

Step 3 — Get Your Agent Working Again

If your agent is stuck and not responding, the quickest fix is to either restart the gateway or switch the primary model to a different provider that's still working. Here are your options, starting with the easiest.

Option A — Try /model in Telegram

If your agent is still processing messages (you can see "typing" but no response), try sending:

```
/model anthropic/claude-sonnet-4-6
```

Or any other model from a different provider. If the agent picks up the command, it will switch immediately. But if it's completely frozen, this won't work and you'll need one of the options below.

Option B — Restart through Hostinger Docker Manager (VPS users)

Log into your Hostinger panel, go to your VPS, and open the Docker Manager. Find your OpenClaw container and click Stop, wait about 10 seconds, then click Start (or use Restart if available). This forces the gateway to restart fresh, which often clears a stuck connection. Wait about a minute after the container shows as running, then try sending a message on Telegram.

Option C — Restart on a local install

If you're running OpenClaw locally, open your terminal and run:

```
openclaw gateway restart
```

Wait about a minute and try sending a message on Telegram. If the gateway was stuck on a timeout, the restart should clear it and the agent will start using the fallback chain properly.

Option D — Through the Dashboard

If you can access your gateway dashboard, you can change the primary model from there. For local install users, open <http://127.0.0.1:18789> in your browser. For VPS users, you'll need to set up an SSH tunnel first (covered in the SSH lesson in Section 7 of the course). In the dashboard, find the model dropdown at the top and switch to a model from a different provider.

Option E — Edit the config file directly (advanced)

Note: This option uses SSH and Docker commands which are covered in Section 7 of the course. If you haven't reached those lessons yet, stick with Options A through D above. Come back to this one later when you're comfortable with SSH.

This is the most reliable method and works even when the agent, Telegram, and the dashboard are all unresponsive. SSH into your server and change the primary model directly in the config file. For example, to switch from OpenAI Codex to Claude Sonnet:

```
docker exec -it openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1 sed -i \  
's/openai-codex/gpt-5.4/anthropic/claude-sonnet-4-6/' \  
/data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

Then restart the container:

```
docker restart openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1
```

Wait about a minute and send a test message on Telegram. Your agent should respond using the new model.

Adapt the command to your setup. Replace openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1 with your actual container name (find it with `docker ps`). Replace the model names with whatever your current primary model is and whichever working model you want to switch to.

Step 4 — Switch Back When the Outage Is Over

Once the provider's status page shows everything is back to normal, you can switch your primary model back. The easiest way is to just tell your agent on Telegram:

```
/model openai-codex/gpt-5.4
```

Or if you used the SSH method to switch, run the same command in reverse — swap the model names around in the sed command and restart the container.

Step 5 — If Your Agent Still Won't Respond After the Outage Is Over

This section is specifically for ChatGPT subscription (OAuth) users. If you connected your ChatGPT subscription to OpenClaw using the OAuth method from the "Adding API Keys & Smart Routing" lesson, read on. If you only use API keys (Anthropic, OpenRouter, Google), you can skip this section.

Sometimes after a provider outage, everything looks fine — the status page says the service is back, you've restarted the container, but your agent still won't respond. It just sits on "typing" forever.

When this happens with a ChatGPT subscription, the most likely cause is that your login session expired during the outage. Think of it like being logged out of a website — the outage disrupted the connection between OpenClaw and your ChatGPT account, and now OpenClaw needs to log in again.

The fix is simple: you just need to log in again, the same way you did when you first connected your ChatGPT subscription. Here's how to do it step by step.

How to re-connect your ChatGPT subscription

First, open a terminal. The way you do this depends on your setup:

VPS users: Open the browser terminal in your Hostinger dashboard (click the Terminal button on your VPS overview page), or SSH in if you know how.

Local install users: Open your regular terminal (Terminal on Mac, PowerShell on Windows).

Step 1 (VPS only): Get inside the OpenClaw container. Local install users skip this step and go straight to Step 2.

```
docker exec -it openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1 bash
```

Replace openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1 with your container name. If you don't know it, type `docker ps` and look for the OpenClaw container in the list.

Step 2 (everyone): Run the login command:

```
openclaw models auth login
```

This opens a menu where you pick which provider to log into. From this point on, the steps are the same for both VPS and local install.

Step 3: Use the arrow keys to scroll down to **OpenAI Codex** and press Enter.

Step 4: OpenClaw will show you a URL. Copy this URL and open it in your browser (on your laptop or phone, not on the server). Log into your ChatGPT account the same way you normally do, and click Authorize when asked.

Step 5: Your browser will redirect to a page that might say "this site can't be reached" — that's normal. Copy the entire URL from your browser's address bar.

Step 6: Go back to your terminal and paste the URL where it's waiting for you. Press Enter.

Step 7: You should see a confirmation message saying OpenAI Codex is connected. Now exit the container (if you're on VPS) by typing exit, and restart:

```
docker restart openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1
```

Wait about 30 seconds, then send /new and hello on Telegram. Your agent should respond normally.

How to tell if this is your problem: If your agent keeps showing "typing" but never replies, and you've already restarted the container and confirmed the provider is back online, it's almost certainly an expired login. The re-login takes about two minutes and solves it every time.

Other Reasons Your Agent Might Not Respond

If the provider status page looks fine and there's no outage, the problem might be on your end. Here are the most common causes with instructions for both VPS and local setups.

Gateway stopped running

VPS: Open Hostinger Docker Manager and check if your OpenClaw container shows as Running (green). If it shows as Stopped, click Start. If you know SSH, you can also check with `docker ps -a` and restart with `docker restart openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1`.

Local install: Open your terminal and run `openclaw gateway status` to check if it's running. If it's stopped, start it with `openclaw gateway start`.

API key expired or revoked

VPS: Go to Hostinger Docker Manager, click Manage, scroll to Environment and check that your API key variables are still there (`OPENROUTER_API_KEY`, `GEMINI_API_KEY`, etc.). If a key looks wrong or is missing, update it and click Save and Deploy.

Local install: Ask your agent on Telegram (if it's partially working) or in the dashboard chat to check if the API key is loaded. If the key is bad, paste a new one to your agent and ask it to update the config.

Both: You can also log into the provider's website (OpenRouter, Google AI Studio, etc.) and check if your key is still active there.

Computer or VPS ran out of memory or disk space

VPS: If you know SSH, connect to your server and run `free -h` to check memory and `df -h` to check disk space. If either is full, you may need to clean up old logs or upgrade your VPS plan. You can also check basic resource usage in the Hostinger VPS dashboard.

Local install: Check your computer's Activity Monitor (Mac) or Task Manager (Windows) to see if memory or disk is full. OpenClaw needs some free memory and disk space to run properly.

Telegram bot token is invalid

Both setups: If Telegram shows no "typing" indicator at all when you send a message, the bot connection might be broken. Open your gateway dashboard and check the Channels section to see if Telegram is listed and connected. If it's not, you may need to paste your bot token again. Check the Telegram Setup Mini Guide PDF for details on how to get a new token from BotFather if needed.

Telegram app is stuck on "typing" or "updating"

Both setups: Sometimes the problem isn't your agent at all — it's the Telegram app on your computer or phone. Your agent might actually be responding (and the logs on the server confirm messages are being sent), but Telegram is stuck showing "typing" or "updating" and never displays the reply. This can happen after an outage, after a restart, or just randomly.

The fix is simple: completely close the Telegram app (not just minimize it — actually quit it) and open it again. On Mac, right-click the Telegram icon in the dock and click Quit, then reopen. On Windows, close the window and check the system tray to make sure it's fully closed. On your phone, swipe the app away and reopen it. Once Telegram reconnects, any messages your agent already sent should appear.

Config broke after a change

Both setups: If you (or your agent) recently changed something in the config and the agent stopped working right after, the config file might be broken. OpenClaw keeps backup copies of your config automatically.

VPS (with SSH): Run `docker exec -it openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1 cp /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json.bak /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json` and then restart the container.

Local install: Find the config folder (usually `~/.openclaw/`) and look for a file called `openclaw.json.bak`. Copy it over the main `openclaw.json` file, then run `openclaw gateway restart`.

Check the logs for error messages

VPS (with SSH): Run `docker logs openclaw-ij7b-openclaw-1 --tail 50` to see the latest log entries. Look for lines with `ERROR` or `WARN` — these usually tell you exactly what went wrong.

Local install: Run `openclaw gateway logs` in your terminal to see recent log entries.

Both: You can also check the Debug and Logs section in your gateway dashboard if you can access it.

Quick Checklist

#	Check	VPS	Local Install
1	Is the provider down?	Check status page	Check status page
2	Is the gateway running?	Hostinger Docker Manager or docker ps -a	openclaw gateway status
3	Any errors in the logs?	docker logs <container> --tail 50	openclaw gateway logs
4	Can I switch model?	/model in Telegram	/model in Telegram
5	Is the API key valid?	Check Hostinger env vars	Ask agent or check config
6	Is Telegram connected?	Check Channels in dashboard	Check Channels in dashboard
7	Need to restart?	Hostinger: Stop then Start or docker restart	openclaw gateway restart
8	OAuth login expired? (ChatGPT subscription only)	openclaw models auth login inside the container	openclaw models auth login in your terminal

The best defence against outages: Set up models from at least two different providers. If your primary is OpenAI, make sure you have Anthropic or Google as a fallback. If your primary is Anthropic, have OpenAI or Google ready. That way you can always switch to a working provider in under a minute.

OpenClaw Masterclass — When Your Agent Stops Responding

Keep this guide handy. Provider outages happen to everyone and knowing what to do saves you a lot of stress.